

rather rapidly decreasing death rates. This type represents a population which is growing fast. Most of the developing countries have this type of population pyramid. Chart 5.2 shows the age pyramid of Sri Lanka at the census years 1946, 1953, 1963 & 1971.

5.5 Changes in age composition

The population at the Censuses of 1946, 1953, 1963 and 1971 by five year age groups is shown in Table 5.3. The population increased by 90.6 percent during the 25 year period 1946-71. This increase, however, has not been uniformly distributed in each age group. The population under 25 years of age has shown increases higher than the average increase of 90.6 percent for the country as a whole, thus reflecting the "baby boom" following the second world war. Also the age groups over 50 years have increased by more than 100 percent. This might have been due to the rapid and spectacular decline of mortality and consequent life expectation in Sri Lanka.

Table 5.4 shows the percentage distribution of the population by 5 year age groups at the Censuses from 1921 onwards. The proportion of children under 5 years which was 14.3 percent of the population in 1921, dropped to 12.9 percent in 1946, but thereafter progressively increased to 14.9 percent in 1953 and 15.3 percent in 1963, and declined to 13.1 percent in 1971. The decline between 1963 and 1971 reflects the decrease in the birth rate that had occurred after 1963.

The percent distribution of the population of Sri Lanka from 1946 onwards according to three broad age groups of 0-14, 15-64 and 65 and over is shown in Table 5.5. It can be observed that Sri Lanka has an extremely young age composition which is a very common feature in the developing countries. In 1971, the population under 15 years of age constituted 39.0 percent of the total population compared to 30 percent or less in many developed countries. On the other hand, those aged 65 years and over constituted only 4.2 percent of the total population in Sri Lanka, while in the developed countries they form more than 10 percent.

5.6 Dependency Ratio

The dependency ratio is used to measure the impact of the age composition on the economic activity of the population. It is assumed that the age group 15-64 years is the productive segment of the population while children under 15 and elderly persons aged 65 years and over are considered dependants. In Sri Lanka the proportion of dependants is very nearly 44 percent. A crude measure of the dependency load that the productive sector of the population must bear is the ratio of the population under 15 years and 65 years and over to the population 15-64 multiplied by 100.

Table 5.5 shows the dependency ratio as at the censuses since 1946.

TABLE 5.5 : PERCENT DISTRIBUTION OF POPULATION IN BROAD AGE GROUPS AND DEPENDENCY RATIO : 1946 - 1971

Census Year	All ages	Age Group			Dependency ratio
		0 - 14	15 - 64	65 & Over	
1946	100.0	37.2	59.3	3.4	68.6
1953	100.0	39.7	56.8	3.5	76.1
1963	100.0	41.8	54.6	3.6	83.0
1971	100.0	39.0	56.8	4.2	76.1